

# Rating Area 5: West Central / Alleghenies

Hub: Altoona / Johnstown | Counties: Bedford, Blair, Cambria, Clearfield, Huntingdon, Jefferson, Somerset

|                                                        |                                                |                                                   |                                               |
|--------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| <b>21.5%</b><br>PID-approved avg. individual rate hike | <b>102%</b><br>avg. net premium increase, 2026 | <b>443,024</b><br>PA enrollees as of June 1, 2026 | <b>160,000+</b><br>cumulative PA terminations |
|--------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|

## THE STATEWIDE PICTURE

The federal enhanced premium tax credits expired December 31, 2025, and Congress has not restored them; combined with the Pennsylvania Insurance Department's (PID) approved 21.5% average individual-market rate increase, Pennie reports the average net premium for the affected population rose 102% for 2026 (Pennsylvania Insurance Department, 2025; Pennie, 2026a). Statewide, 85,000 people dropped Pennie coverage during Open Enrollment; as of June 1, 2026, cumulative cancellations exceed 160,000 and total enrollment stands at 443,024 (Pennie, 2026a, 2026b). Pennsylvania's own relief program, the Act 54 state subsidy, remains unfunded as the state budget missed its June 30, 2026 deadline for the fifth year running (Spotlight PA, 2026).

## CARRIERS & RATES IN THIS AREA

A rural, mountainous footprint served by Geisinger, UPMC Health Options, and Highmark (Pennsylvania Insurance Department, 2025b). This area's hospitals rely disproportionately on a stable insured population; rating areas with high proportional coverage loss statewide have also seen the sharpest rise in uncompensated hospital care since the subsidy cliff took effect (Pennsylvania Insurance Department, 2025).

**BRONZE PLANS: READ THE DEDUCTIBLE BEFORE THE PREMIUM**  
Statewide, Bronze-tier enrollment rose roughly 30% this cycle as households chased lower premiums (Pennie, 2026a). Nationally for 2026, KFF puts the average Bronze deductible at \$7,186 versus \$5,304 for Silver (KFF, 2026) — in a region with fewer nearby hospital systems, confirm your Bronze plan's network before assuming the lower premium is the better deal.

## YOUR CONSUMER PROTECTIONS

**If a directory error sends you out-of-network:** 28 Pa. Code § 9.725 caps your liability at in-network cost-sharing, and Act 252 of 2023 presumes an undisclosed out-of-network balance bill illegal. The federal IDR process (45 C.F.R. § 149.510) is a *provider-vs-plan* tool only — you cannot file one yourself; use the protections above instead.

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|-------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Enroll / compare plans:</b> pennie.com or 1-844-844-8040 | <b>File a complaint:</b> pa.gov/consumer or 1-866-722-6675 |
| <b>Free legal help:</b> phlp.org or 1-800-274-3258          | <b>Medicare counseling:</b> PA MEDI 1-800-783-7067         |

**SOURCES (APA)**

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